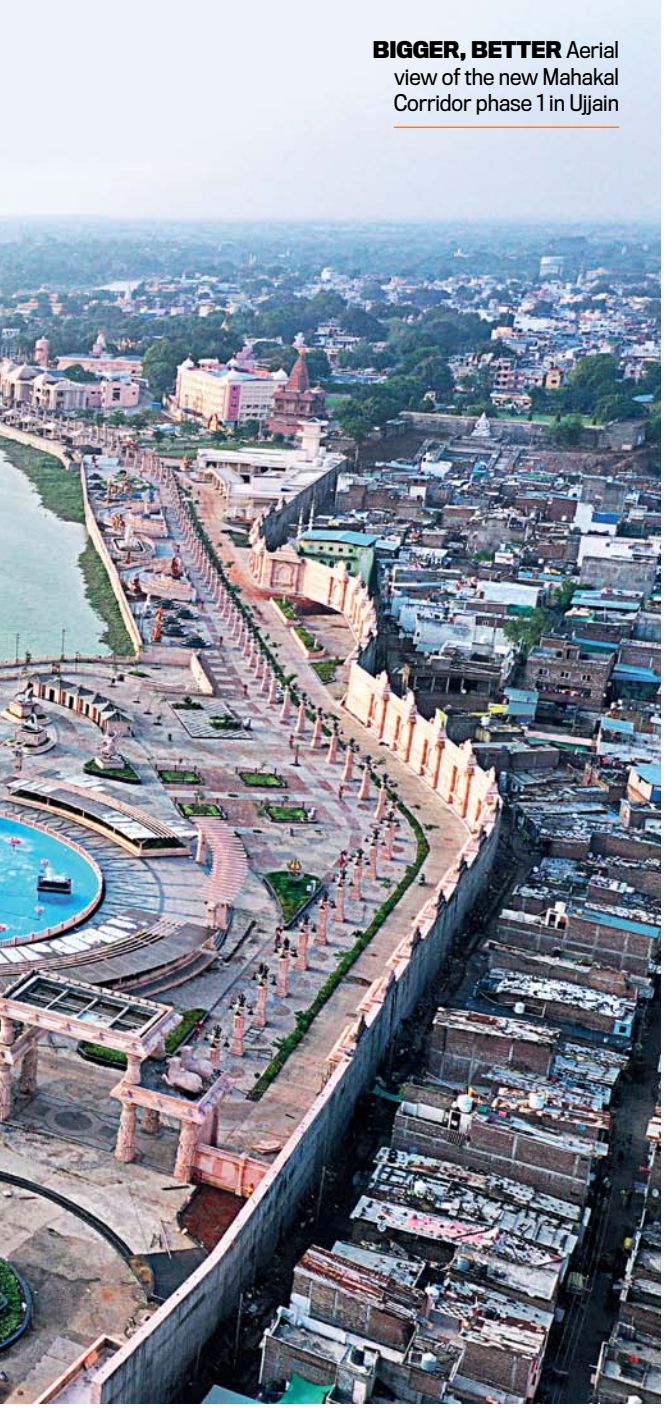
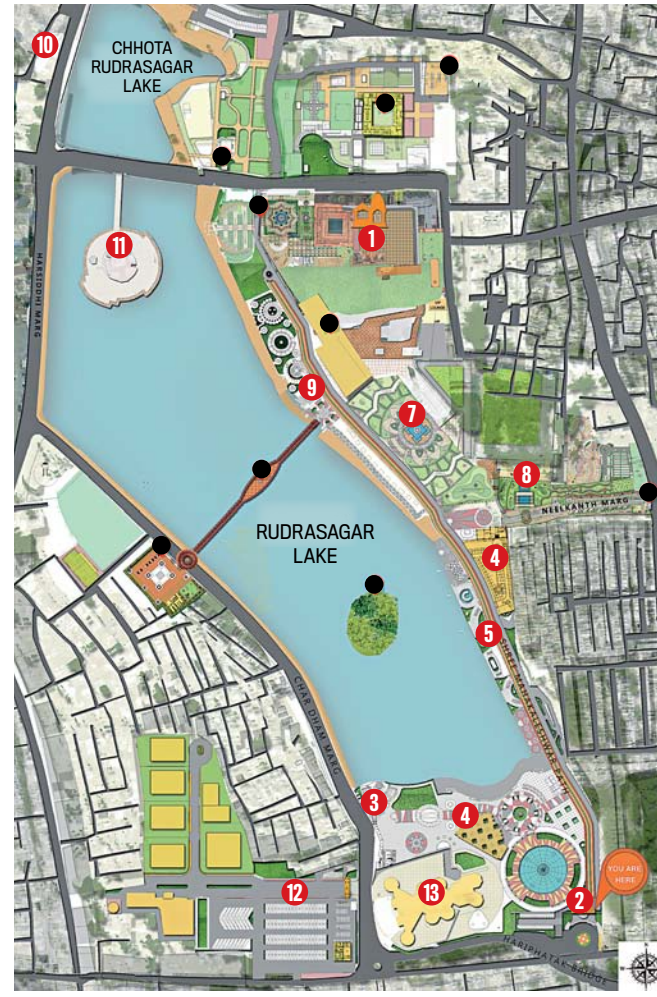


BIGGER, BETTER Aerial view of the new Mahakal Corridor phase 1 in Ujjain

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



PHASE-1 PLAN

1. Mahakal Temple
2. Nandi Dwaar
3. Pinaki Dwaar
4. Public Plaza/ Mahakaleshwar Vatika
5. Lakefront development
6. Madhyanchal/ control room/ handicraft shops
7. Pratikalpa Prangan
8. Neelkanth van (forest)
9. VFC-Visitor facility centre
10. Harsiddhi temple (existing)
11. Singhasan Battisi (existing)
12. Surface parking
13. Triveni useum

PHASE II: ● Locations under consideration

UJJAIN, THE ANCIENT CITY ON THE BANKS OF THE KSHIPRA, has been the capital of many a prominent ruling dynasty. Today, the city is considered the spiritual capital of Madhya Pradesh, with the iconic Mahakal temple as its centrepiece. One of the 12 jyotirlingas, Lord Shiva is represented here as Mahakal, the god of time and death. The MP government has for some time now been involved in an ambitious renovation project, the Shree Mahakal Lok, of the areas surrounding the temple complex. Phase I of the project complete, Prime Minister Narendra Modi will inaugurate it on October 11.

So, what is the Mahakal Corridor, as the project was initially called? It is an attempt to decongest and develop the area around the temple by creating more open spaces, enhancing the visitor experience and benefit the local economy.

The Mahakal temple is located in the heart of the city and the rising number of devotees has stressed the local infrastructure, inconveniencing the devotees themselves and becoming a security nightmare for the administration. Temple authorities say footfalls peak on Saturdays, Sundays and Mondays, with the average number of visitors at around 11,000, while on other days it's about half of this. Devotee footfall increases massively during the month of *saavan* (spring), ranging from 40,000-50,000 a day. The Shivratri/ Nagpanchami rush draws around 500,000 pilgrims.

Located in the old town area, the temple has narrow approach roads. Financed jointly by the Centre, the state gov-